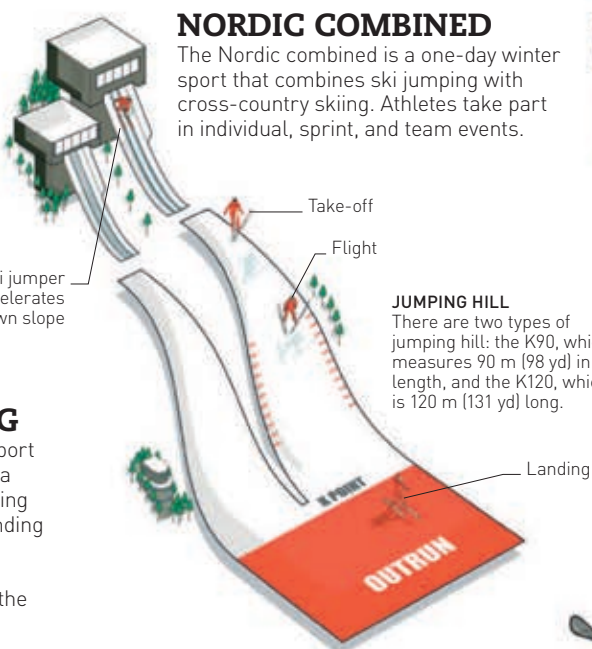




SKI JUMPING

This is a spectacular sport that involves skiing down a steep slope, taking off, jumping as far as possible, and then landing smoothly without falling over. Ski jumpers are judged not only for the furthest distance jumped, but also for the style of their take-off, flight, and landing.



JUMPING HILL

There are two types of jumping hill: the K90, which measures 90 m (98 yd) in length, and the K120, which is 120 m (131 yd) long.

Landing



BIATHLON

The Biathlon is a sport that combines cross-country skiing with rifle shooting. It has a military origin in 18th-century Scandinavia, when accurate shooting and fast skiing were vital for soldiers patrolling the long borders between Norway and Sweden.

Long ski poles help skier to push forward

Cross-country skis have curved tips

SLIDING SPORTS

Sliding sports are among the fastest winter sports. They include bobsleigh, luge, and skeleton. Competitors in each of these sports propel themselves down a specially constructed track and try to reach the bottom in the fastest time possible.

BOBSLEIGH

Bobsleigh was invented in Switzerland in the 19th century. The modern sport sees teams of two or four racing down ice-covered tracks in steerable sleds.



1 ROCK AND SLIDE

After taking up their positions, team members rock the sled and then push off down the launch pad.

2 FINAL PUSH

All members of the team must jump into the sled within 50 m (55 yd) of the start line.

3 FULL STEAM AHEAD

The driver sits at the front and steers the speeding sled.

THE TRACK

All sliding sports take place on a specially constructed ice-covered track. The tracks feature left and right turns, S-curves, 180-degree bends (called "Omega"), and hairpins.

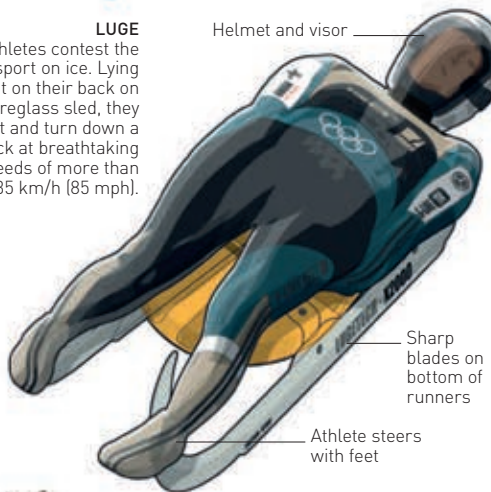


SKELETON

Skeleton is the oldest sliding sport. It requires enormous courage. Athletes travel headfirst down the track on a 120 cm (48 in) long sled called a "skeleton".

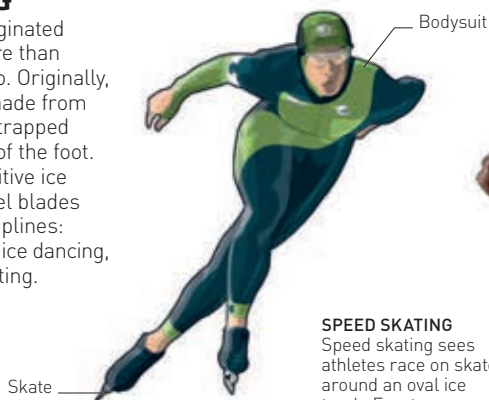
LUGE

Luge athletes contest the fastest sport on ice. Lying feet first on their back on a fibreglass sled, they twist and turn down a track at breathtaking speeds of more than 135 km/h (85 mph).



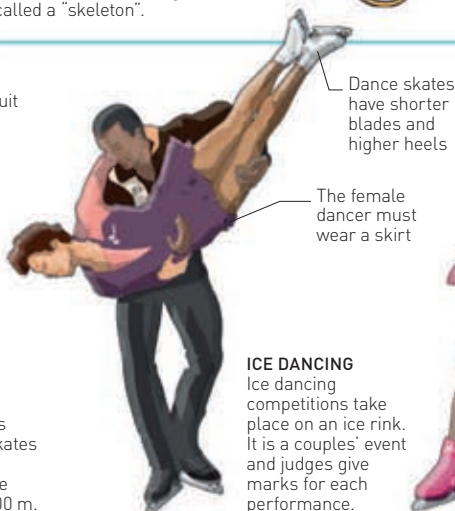
SKATING

Ice skating originated in Finland more than 3000 years ago. Originally, skates were made from animal bone strapped to the bottom of the foot. Today, competitive ice skating on steel blades has three disciplines: speed skating, ice dancing, and figure skating.



SPEED SKATING

Speed skating sees athletes race on skates around an oval ice track. Events range from 500 m to 5,000 m.



ICE DANCING

Ice dancing competitions take place on an ice rink. It is a couples' event and judges give marks for each performance.

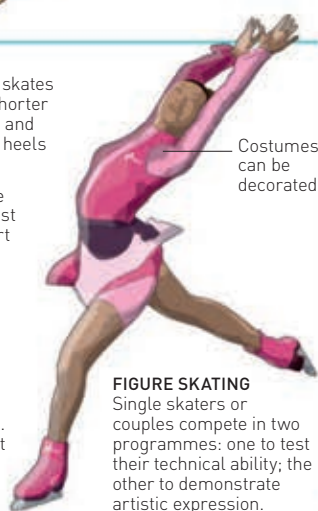


FIGURE SKATING

Single skaters or couples compete in two programmes: one to test their technical ability; the other to demonstrate artistic expression.

TOP FIGURE SKATERS

GILLIS GRAFSTROM (SWEDEN)

Won three consecutive men's singles gold medals at the 1920, 1924, and 1928 Winter Olympic Games.

SONJA HENIE (NORWAY)

Dominated the women's singles event, winning Winter Olympic gold in 1928, 1932, and 1936.

JAYNE TORVILL AND CHRISTOPHER DEAN (UK)

The British ice-dancing pair received the only perfect score in the event's history following their routine at the 1984 Winter Olympic Games.